

was certain that I was prying around for information on his Colgate trades. He held his *sauda* pad close to his chest and shot me a dirty look.

The only thing left for me to do was to get back to Bunty and tell him I had been unsuccessful. I knew Bunty would not hold it against me, but I did not want to give up so easily. A stock exchange clerk by the name of Rajesh, with whom I had become friendly of late, travelled most days by the same local as I did after work. I told him about my requirement and promised him money if he could fish out the details. Rajesh promised to do something about it. Two days later he got me the details. I suspect he sourced them from one of the officials who was privy to the scribblings on the jobbers' *sauda* pads. I paid Rajesh Rs 5,000 for the information.

Later that evening I met Bunty over drinks to give him the information he had asked for. He was very pleased and, in fact, surprised that I had managed to get it for him. 'But this is going to cost you, Bunty; I had to pay Rs 20,000 to get this piece of information because I had to tap more than one source,' I told him, after we had downed a couple of pegs.

Bunty took a sip of his drink and gave me a knowing smile. I realized he had caught my bluff. 'No problem, Lala. You shall get the balance,' he said, and then added as an afterthought, 'You are smarter than I thought, you sure will go far.'

It was more a back-handed compliment than a well-meaning one. But I had formed the first of the many rules I would set for myself over the years. Rule number one: if you are dealing straight, you'll get the same from me. And if you are looking to steal . . . I will deal with you likewise.

Bunty came up with similar requests a few more times, and on each occasion Rajesh passed on the required information to me. I did make good money on these deals, but my firm gained too as Bunty routed more of his trades through us.

---

There was an auction system on BSE. When a seller failed to deliver shares on settlement day, his position would be auctioned. BSE would put up the details of the undelivered shares on the notice board, and other brokers could tender shares to the clearing house. Offering brokers would quote a premium to the last traded price, and the lowest offer would be accepted by the clearing house. Sometimes, when a broker or his client defaulted on